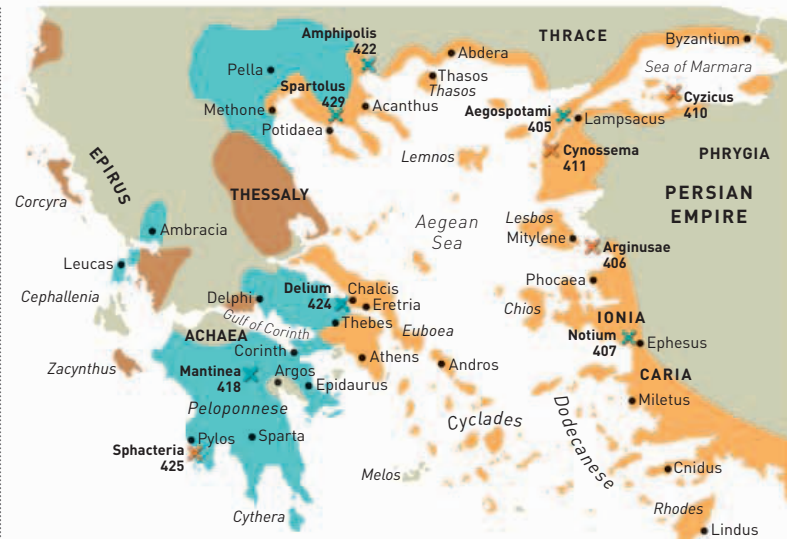
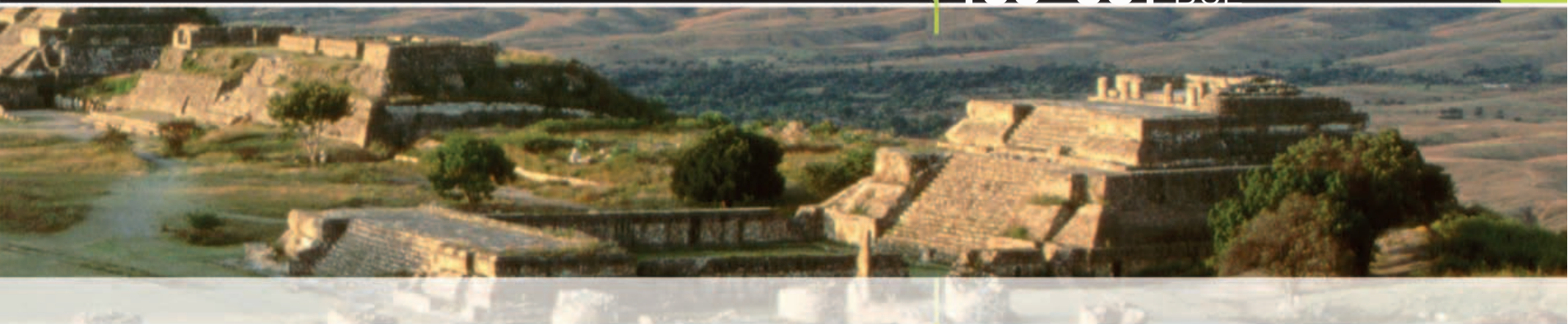




The Great Peloponnesian War
The period of 431–404 BCE saw the destruction of the Athenian Empire at the hands of a coalition of Sparta and its allies.

KEY
 ■ Athenian Empire
 ■ Athenian ally
 ■ Sparta and allied states
 ■ neutral territory
 ✕ Athenian victory
 ✕ Spartan victory

2,800
ATHENIANS

420

Spartans

BATTLE OF SPHACTERIA 425 BCE

in 416 BCE by capturing Melos—the only main Aegean island not in its possession—but fatally overreached itself in 415 BCE with an expedition to Sicily, ending in the **total destruction** of the Athenian force by the **Syracusans** in 413 BCE. The Spartans, meanwhile, established a fort at Decelea in Attica that denied the Athenians access to the rich silver mines. An alliance with Persia further strengthened Sparta's position in 412 BCE, and a year later the democratic regime in Athens

7,000
ATHENIANS18,500
BOEOTIANS

BATTLE OF DELIUM 424 BCE

was briefly overthrown. Democracy was restored the following year, and, although the Athenians won victories at Cyzicus in 410 BCE and Arginusae in 406 BCE, the **total destruction of their fleet at Aegospotami** off Ionia in 405 BCE left Athens defenseless. The Spartans blockaded the city, and, despite a determined resistance, the **Athenians were forced to surrender**. Athens was deprived of its fleet and in 404 BCE a pro-Spartan Council of Thirty was installed to govern it.

30,000
ATHENIANS

3,000

Spartans

SIEGE OF SYRACUSE 415–413 BCE

In Magadha in **India** the Haryanka dynasty founded by Bimbisara was replaced c. 413 BCE after the death of Ajatashatru (c. 459 BCE) and a series of ineffectual rulers. **Shishunaga founded a new dynasty**, which was responsible for overseeing the final transfer of the Magadha royal capital to **Pataliputra**. The Shishunaga dynasty lasted only 500 years.

AFTER ITS VICTORY IN THE PELOPONNESIAN WAR, Sparta found itself embroiled in a quarrel with Persia over whether the Ionian Greek cities should regain their autonomy. Through the 390s BCE, sporadic fighting and abortive peace talks diverted Sparta from a weakening position in mainland Greece. The **"King's Peace,"** a definitive treaty with Persia in 386 BCE, deprived the Ionians of autonomy but allowed the Spartans to quash any threats to its supremacy. In 385 BCE, they attacked Mantinea in the central Peloponnese and in 382 BCE occupied Thebes. Spartan power seemed unassailable.

In Persia, the **death of Darius II** (r. 423–404 BCE) was followed by a **brief civil war**, when Cyrus the Younger tried to overthrow his older brother **Artaxerxes II**

(r. 404–358 BCE). Cyrus was defeated and killed at the **Battle of Cunaxa** in 401 BCE, but in its aftermath some 10,000 Greek mercenaries were left trapped in northern Mesopotamia. Under **Xenophon**, the Greeks marched to the Black Sea coast and safety near Trapezus (Trabzon in modern-day Turkey), a feat their commander immortalized in his book *Anabasis*.

In Italy, the **Romans widened their territory** and annexed the city of Veii in 396 BCE, whose submission represented the **end of any Etruscan threat**. However, c. 390 BCE, an army of Celts, who had been attacking the Etruscan city of Clusium, turned south, defeated a Roman army at the Battle of the Allia, and then **took Rome** itself. This disaster haunted the Romans for centuries.



Etruscan tomb painting

The Etruscan language has never been deciphered, so it is through the frescoes in their tombs that much has been learned of their culture.

